

HOCKS



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direct electoral confrontation with BJP in four state polls—Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Delhi and Chhattisgarh—at the end of 2008. Party veteran Pranab Mukherjee stressed the need to find a new strategy for taking on the communal forces as the Gujarat model had failed. Most of the Congress strategists such as Patel and Mukherjee clearly feel that the party should not apologise for its *maut ka saudagar* (merchant of death) comment but rather step up the aggressive tone against the BJP's brand of Hindutva. "Sonia's comment did not cost us votes, but the flip-flop over it did. There was pressure from the local leaders not to target Modi over communal issues but we are not a regional party. We have to see things from a national perspective. Before Sonia's comment, we were being accused of soft Hindutva in Gujarat," said a party general secretary. Most Congressmen seem to agree, at a time when BJP is hoping to cash in on Modi's hardline appeal by exporting Hindutva to other states. Another reason for this return to aggression and a strong anti-communal card is pressure from UPA allies, particularly RJD and the Left, who feel that going soft on communal issues will harm their vote bank.

Accordingly, at least four general secretaries are now selling the spin that after the Gujarat elections, Sonia has clearly emerged as the chief crusader against communal forces. There will be no more flip-flops. They also talk of Sonia's instinctive antipathy to RSS. Her scribbled comments on an internal memo debating whether the Congress should admit BJP rebel Vallabh Kathiria in October this year are being cited as an example. On the margin of this note, Sonia had categorically stated, "Welcoming someone from RSS goes against my principles and those of the Congress party."

Despite these strong principles the party still gave seven tickets to BJP rebels. Of these, only one won. The

THE WAVE THAT WASN'T: Sonia and Rahul failed to click in the state

central leadership blames the state unit for this, complaining that during the 2002 polls, the Gujarat unit had accused the central leadership of riding roughshod over its views. This time, 18 state Gujarat leaders were summoned for dinner at General Secretary Prithviraj Chavan's house on October 31 and asked whether they wanted to admit the BJP rebels into the party. Seventeen said yes, despite being told of Sonia's views. They felt that only BJP politicians could take on Modi. Now the central leadership says that it will depend less on the judgement of local leaders and, instead, stick to a larger national policy even for state elections. As party general secretary Digvijay Singh summed it up, "Ours should not be a cocktail party where any mixture is allowed in. We should only stick to committed Congressmen."

Though few admit it, the role of Sonia and Rahul Gandhi as the party's star campaigners has been dented. At the AICC session in October, Sonia had told party workers that neither she nor Rahul had a *jadu ki chadi* (magic wand). Gujarat has proved her right, that too at a time when the memory of Rahul's Uttar Pradesh campaign, which pulled down the party's tally from 25 to 22 MLAs, is still fresh. The silver lining in this—and where the heir apparent is concerned, the Congress looks hard for one—is that by campaigning in both Gujarat and Himachal Pradesh, their young leader is no longer confining himself to just Uttar Pradesh. "We could not convert their crowds into votes," protests B.K. Hariprasad, general secretary in charge of Gujarat.

While it is easy to blame the organisation, it is also the central command that is at fault for failing to build the state-level leadership. If there was a local leader to take on Modi, the state fight would not have been pitched at a Modi vs Sonia level. Forget grooming new leaders, the party is eager to cut down the old, established ones. Chief ministers like Sheila Dikshit and Vilasrao Deshmukh are routinely pulled up by the command while Amarinder Singh was made to wait for weeks before he got an audience at 10, Janpath when he was still the Punjab chief minister. A Narendra Modi would have been cut down to size by the Congress high command long before